

EYEWITNESS February 1, 1968

Saigon Execution

One of the most famous images of the Vietnam War captures the moment ARVN General Nguyen Ngoc Loan executes a Viet Cong officer on a street in Saigon. The photographer, Eddie Adams, recalls both the moment he took the shocking image and the impact it had on the general's life.

On that day in February, Adams was taking occasional pictures as three men walked toward him. When they were about five feet away, the soldiers stopped and backed away. A man walked into his camera viewfinder, took a pistol out of his holster, and raised it to the head of the Viet Cong officer. Expecting this man to interrogate the officer, Adams got ready to take a picture. But the man shot the Viet Cong officer in the temple at the same time as Adams took the photo.

This photograph had a negative impact on the life of General Nguyen Ngoc Loan. Adams claimed he killed the general with his camera that day, and that he felt bad for him and his family for a long time after. Photographs capture a moment but they do not ask the viewer what they would have done if they were there at that time and place.

“Photographs are the most powerful weapons in the world. People believe them; but photographs do lie.”

EDDIE ADAMS, OBITUARY FOR NGUYEN NGOC LOAN, *TIME* MAGAZINE, JULY 27, 1998